

B. C. FORBES

1880–1954

The future founder of a publishing empire was one of 10 children born to a tailor in Scotland. To help support the family, B. C. Forbes started working at the age of 14, when he unfortunately agreed to a 7-year apprenticeship as a compositor for a newspaper for 75 cents a week (he thought he was being hired to be a writer as in composition). "I soon discovered" he recalled, "that what I had agreed to become meant that I was to stand in front of cases of type, day after day, month after month for seven years, doing nothing but pick up one metallic letter at a time . . . I felt as if I had been sentenced to seven years penal servitude." Not one to give up, Forbes decided he would "make them want to make me a reporter." At night he took a course in shorthand, a prerequisite for reporters, and he did indeed get a job writing.

It took a woman to break his spirit. After the object of his affection decided to marry someone else, Forbes left Scotland. "I shook the dust of Scotland off my feet," he said, "and sailed for the remotest corner of the world I could think of, South Africa, then in the close of the Boer War, where I figured I could find enough excitement to assuage my black, black woe." After two years in South Africa, he came to the United States. In New York City he started writing for a number of papers, covering business from the money market to the foreign exchange. When William Randolph Hearst decided he wanted better financial pages in his *New York American* newspaper, he recruited Forbes, who consequently became Hearst's best-known financial columnist.

Forbes founded his namesake magazine in 1917. He was going to call it *Doers and Doings*, but friends convinced him to change his mind; they believed his name alone was a great marketing tool. Even after Forbes founded his magazine, Hearst asked him to write a syndicated financial column. The astute observer of Wall Street happenings agreed. Forbes was not afraid to attack such infamous Wall Street men as Jay Gould, whom he criticized for "his narrowness of vision, his unreasoning jealousy, his chronic suspicions, etc." Drawing on his experiences with both scoundrels and heroes, he offers his view of the typical Wall Street operator in *Wall Street Millionaires*.